

GOING UNDER
The crashed section of the Sultanganj bridge

RANJAN RAHI

A BRIDGE THAT KEEPS FALLING DOWN

AN UNDER-CONSTRUCTION BRIDGE IN BIHAR COLLAPSING TWICE IN JUST OVER A YEAR IS SYMPTOMATIC OF THE APATHY THAT AFFECTS INFRA PROJECTS IN THE STATE

By AMITABH SRIVASTAVA *in Bhagalpur*

IT **was a sultry Sunday evening** and Ajit Kumar was outside giving his car a wipedown when he heard the deafening crash. He initially thought it was a lightning strike, but then realised it was the under-construction Aguwani-Sultanganj bridge. A 575-metre portion of the bridge (Pylons 9 to 13) had crumbled into the Ganga. "The dust from the debris hung over the river for some time. It was scary," recalls Ajit, who owns Hotel Ashoka Garden, which overlooks the Sultanganj Ghat in Bihar's Bhagalpur district.

The 3.16 km long bridge connecting Sultanganj and Aguwani Ghat in Khagaria district, being built by S.P. Singla Construction Private Ltd, has had a jinxed journey so far. The June 4 collapse was the second major accident in just over a year. Earlier, on April 30, 2022, a 162.5 metre stretch of the bridge's extradosed span, involving 19 segments on both sides of Pylon 5, had crashed (see *A Bridge Too Far*).

Even in a state known for its many bridges, the Aguwani-Sultanganj was supposed to be a